HEALTHWATCH: A NEW CANCER VACCINE? PG 12

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PLUMES FOR PEACE
PM Narendra Modi at an event in Churachandpur, Manipur, Sept. 13

▶ MISSION EAST

PM'S NEW POLL PLANK

Not peace or development but addressing the widely perceived threat from illegal migration was the dominant theme running through PM Modi's tour of the east

By KAUSHIK DEKA

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's tour of eastern states from September 13 to 15, sweeping through Mizoram, Manipur, Assam, West Bengal and Bihar, ostensibly showcased the government's commitment to regional development. Yet beneath the project inaugurations lay a political stratagem. The PM's first visit to Manipur since ethnic clashes erupted in May 2023 might have been expected to herald serious reconciliation efforts between the Meitei and Kuki-Zo communities. Instead, it turned out to be an exercise in crystallising the theme of illegal immigration as the BJP's defining electoral narrative for impending assembly elections—Bihar later this year, followed by West Bengal and Assam in 2026. Its overall tenor could can be linked to Modi's Independence Day announcement of a national "demography mission" to address anxieties about demographic change, particularly in border states. Modi's itinerary, in turn, allowed him to weave that broader theme into a tapestry of local grievances.

MISSES IN MANIPUR?

Consider the PM's approach to Manipur, where he spent barely half a day, split between Kuki-dominated Churachandpur and Meitei stronghold Imphal. In Churachandpur, Modi talked about development projects and appealed for peace. However, in capital Imphal, he also spoke about cross-border infiltration. The Meitei community allege that an influx of Chin refugees from Myanmar—ethnically affiliated with Kuki-Zos—has altered the state's demographic equilibrium. The Kuki-Zos assert their indigenous status and view the anti-immigration drive as a thinly-veiled excuse for ethnic expansionism and land grab. One of the triggers behind the violence that has claimed over 200 lives and displaced 60,000 people was former chief minister Biren Singh's aggressive campaign against "illegal immigrants from Myanmar". By reprising that theme in Imphal, Modi validated the premise of Meitei grievances.

The reception to Modi's outreach efforts in Manipur is revealing. Meitei civil society leaders decried his silence on their core demands, notably the abrogation of the Suspension of Operations agreement with Kuki armed groups, which was instead extended. Kuki groups, for their part, have been consistent in demanding a separate administration—if not Union Territory status—for their areas, a proposal rejected by Delhi.

Thokchom Sujata, convenor of the Meitei